THE BYZANTINES

The Byzantine Empire was the continuation of the Roman Empire in the east and its armed forces at first followed the Roman professional model. In the 7th century, however, when the empire came under threat from Muslim Arab forces, a new form of military organization emerged. The empire was divided into military districts known as "themes", each under the command of a general or "strategos". Soldiers were granted land to support themselves, as the empire could not afford to pay them.

From the 8th century, Byzantium put more reliance upon the "tagmata", cavalry and infantry regiments in the direct employ of the emperor. There was also an increasing use of foreign auxiliaries and mercenaries, including the famous Varangian Guard. The crack troops were armoured cavalry, the cataphracts. These differed from West European knights in carrying bows as well as swords and lances; they also lacked the special social status that went with knighthood. The cataphracts typically made repeated lance charges in waves supported by a rain of arrows, wearing down the enemy rather than attempting to break through in a single mass charge. By the start of the 11th century, when Basil II, known as the Bulgar-slayer, was emperor, the Byzantine army was one of the world's most effective fighting forces. It never fully recovered, however, from defeat by the Seljuk Turks at Manzikert in 1071.



Byzantine cataphracts
Like other medieval heavy cavalrymen, when not fighting Byzantine cataphracts carried their shields slung over their backs. Horses were sometimes armoured as well as the riders.

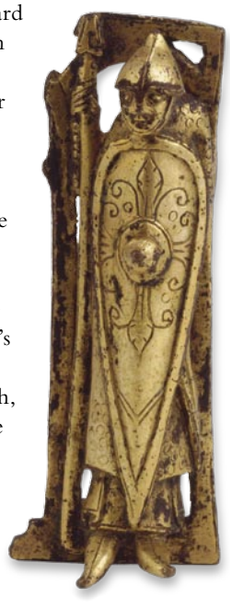
THE NORMANS

A Viking warband commanded by Rollo settled in northern France in 911, with the agreement of the Frankish king, Charles the Simple. Rollo's descendants became the Dukes of Normandy. Because of intermarriage with other inhabitants of France, by the 11th century the Normans' Scandinavian blood was much diluted, but the warrior spirit of their intrepid ancestors remained very much alive.

Norman conquests were wide-ranging. In the Mediterranean, the Norman adventurer Robert Guiscard and his brothers took over southern Italy and Sicily after defeating the forces of the Holy Roman Emperor Henry III at Civitate in 1053. They were repeatedly victorious against the Byzantine Greeks and threatened to attack Constantinople in the 1080s. Normans were also prominent in the First Crusade, which captured Jerusalem from the Muslims in 1099. Robert Guiscard's son Bohemond founded and ruled the Norman principality of Antioch, situated in northwest Syria. But the Normans' most famous conquest was undoubtedly that of England, accomplished by Duke William the Bastard and his followers after a cross-Channel invasion from Normandy in 1066.



Norman helmet
The Normans wore a conical helm made of sheet iron. While offering some protection, it would not have been strong enough to withstand a direct blow with a sword or axe.



Crusading knight
This knight armed with a spear wears a Norman helmet and carries a Norman shield. The distinctive long, kite-shaped shield is emblazoned with a cross that indicates that the knight is a crusader.

FIGHTING METHODS

A Norman army always included considerable numbers of foot soldiers. These comprised armoured infantry with spears and bowmen – light archers with simple bows and a lesser number of crossbowmen. But it was heavy cavalry that constituted the cream of the Norman forces. These horsemen did not yet have the social status of the medieval knight; they were simply professional fighting men who could afford to own a warhorse. A Norman knight would join the entourage of a nobleman in the hope of reward through victory in war. It was only after the conquest of England that a full-blown "feudal" system developed, with knights owing service to their overlord – and ultimately the king – in return for land ("fiefs").

The Normans were skilled at war because they practised it constantly. Normandy was the site of endless low-level warfare involving raids and sieges that kept the fighting men actively occupied. They were expert castle-builders, although until the 12th century these were usually forts of earth and wood rather than stone structures. The Normans built castles as part of an offensive strategy, regarding them as military bases from which mobile forces would sally forth to exercise control over a conquered region.